

The Hour of the Predator: Encounters with the Autocrats and Tech Billionaires Taking Over the World

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Location: 138

‘On this earth, there is something terrible, and it’s the fact that everybody has their reasons.’ This observation, from the Jean Renoir film *The Rules of the Game*, finds concrete form in an institution whose purpose is to bring all these reasons into contact with one another. But this is not a theoretical process. The UN General Assembly is, above all, a question of bodies.

Location: 260

Once the chaos goes beyond a certain stage, the only way to restore order is to identify a scapegoat. And the leader, any leader, is always a scapegoat-in-waiting. Tolstoy compared the leader to a ram fattened for slaughter. Fattened on triumph, on the obedience of his subjects, on power and wealth, only to be suddenly struck down by the same force that raised him. I hope Zelensky can escape that fate. But the laws of politics tolerate few exceptions.

Location: 279

In politics, though, it is not only when you fall from grace that you suffer. Politics is a world of perpetual pain. You have to be a certain kind of person to bear it.

Location: 290

One of Starmer’s predecessors, Tony Blair, has just published a book in which he says that political leaders generally go through three stages. First, when they take power, they are willing listeners who know that they don’t know everything, and they try to understand how best to interpret their role. After a while, they become convinced that they have gained sufficient experience and they know enough to imagine that they have understood how everything works. This is the most dangerous phrase, when hubris takes hold. ‘They’re impatient with listening,’ Blair writes. ‘They’re the boss. Who can know more than them?’ Finally there is the mature stage, when the leader realizes that his experience does not constitute the sum total of political knowledge and he starts listening to others again. Most leaders, according to Blair, never reach this stage.

Location: 369

All over the world, war fever is catching, and liberal democracies are not immune to the contagion. The United States has moved from the era of hard-fought negotiations among diplomats to that of kinetic diplomacy through military force. In recent years, the illusion that technological supremacy could take the place of in-depth analysis of different local situations in foreign policy has transformed the use of weaponry, physical and digital, from a last resort to an easy first option. In such a context, sophisticated sherpas have become a dying breed. For as long as anyone can remember, career diplomats made up about three-quarters of American ambassadorial appointments, with the remaining quarter being handed out to presidential donors. From 2017, however, Donald Trump reversed this ratio, appointing mostly his own supporters to these positions. His return in 2025 has already shown signs that it might lead to the complete extinction of career ambassadors.

Location: 436

These days, attack is cheaper than defence. Much cheaper. And the price keeps coming down. In the future, some believe, a single individual will be able to declare

war on the rest of the world—and win. When you bear in mind that a DNA synthesizer with the potential to create fatal new pathogens costs about \$20,000—the price of a used car—this does not seem especially far-fetched.

Location: 448

Today, our democracies appear more solid. But nobody can doubt that the toughest test is yet to come. The new American president is at the head of a motley procession of shameless autocrats, tech conquistadors, reactionaries and conspiracy theorists, all spoiling for a fight. An era of limitless violence lies ahead of us, and, as in Leonardo's time, the defenders of freedom seem singularly unprepared for the battle to come.

Location: 569

The Prince is a usurper's guide to conquering and ruling. There are many lessons to be drawn from its pages for Borgias of all eras, but one of them stands out above all the others: the first law of strategy is action. In a situation of uncertainty, when the legitimacy of power is precarious and can be called into question at any moment, he who fails to act can be sure that change will happen anyway—to his disadvantage.

Location: 573

If Tolstoy shows us that the condition of the powerful man is always to be thwarted, since the fulfilment of his will depends on the will of so many other people that it becomes practically impossible, meaning that the lowest infantryman in Napoleon's army has more freedom than the emperor himself, then the resolute action of a prince constitutes the solution to this problem. This is what today's Kremlin insiders call 'manual override'. When the system, with all its procedures and hierarchies, no longer produces the desired result, there remains the possibility of direct intervention: breaking the official rules to re-establish substantive justice.

Location: 578

But for the miracle of power to happen, it takes more than a resolute action. The action must also be reckless, because what is the point of an action that simply responds to necessity? That would be little more than the act of a technocrat, one of those cruel, grey functionaries who act in the name of constraints from on high, which they claim only they can control. The essence of power resides in the very opposite of this. Goethe tells the story of an old Saxon duke, intuitive and wilful, who was urged to think carefully before making an important decision. 'I don't want to think carefully,' he replied. 'Otherwise, what would be the point of being Duke of Saxony?'

The apogee of power coincides not so much with action as with reckless action, which is the only kind that will shock people. And shock is the foundation of the prince's power.

Location: 691

What has changed from the way it was eight years ago is that the pedestal on which the old order stood has collapsed. In the mid 2010s, Trump, Bolsonaro and the Brexiters were able to appear like a group of outsiders, defying the established order and adopting a strategy of chaos, like guerrilla insurgents battling a superior force. Now the situation has been reversed: chaos is no longer the weapon of the rebels, but the banner of those in power.

Location: 696

All the guardrails of the old world—the respect for the independence of certain institutions, human and minority rights, a concern for international repercussions—have no value now that the hour of the predator is upon us.

Location: 701

The window of opportunity that existed until recently for a system of rules to be put in place has now closed. The very idea of a limit to the logic of force, finance or cryptocurrency, to the growing power of AI and technological convergence, or to the upending of the international order in favour of the law of the jungle, is no longer conceivable. In this new era, the Borgians have an advantage because they are used to existing in a world without limits. They are not content to resist adversity; they draw their strength from instability, unpredictability, aggression.

Location: 716

When it comes down to it, Trump is merely yet another illustration of one of the obvious, unchanging principles of politics: there is practically no connection between intellectual power and political intelligence. The world is full of highly intelligent people—even among political specialists and experts—who understand absolutely nothing about politics, whereas a functional illiterate like Trump has a sort of natural genius for interpreting the zeitgeist.

Location: 741

There is nothing more violent than politics. Soldiers fight only when they are at war, but politics is a forever war. A politician's most dangerous enemies are almost always hiding in the ranks of their own army, and the speed at which everything occurs further reduces the margin of error and increases the mortality rate. In this milieu, intellectuals are generally useless because they never put their hand to their sword hilt—a fatal mistake in a game where risk-taking is the only real currency.

Location: 752

The hour of the predator is essentially just a return to normality. The anomaly was the brief period during which we believed that we could curb the bloody quest for power with a system of rules.

Location: 760

In this, the hour of the predator, it is no longer leaders in formerly peripheral states who are trying to resemble our leaders, but Western leaders adopting non-native traits.

Location: 766

All that matters is the result. As Javier Milei put it so succinctly: 'What is the difference between a madman and a genius? Success!' This is the credo of the Borgians, now shared by a majority of the world's population, who have stopped regarding the rules as a guarantee of their freedom and started to see them as a gigantic swindle, if not an elite conspiracy, designed to oppress them.

Location: 774

Borgians focus on substance, not form. They promise to solve the people's real problems: crime, immigration, the cost of living. And how do their opponents respond, all those liberals and progressives and democrats? They respond with rules, democracy in peril, protection for minorities, et cetera.

Location: 834

Having given up the idea of transforming (or even regulating) capitalism, having given up fighting against economic inequality, the Democrats fell back on the less ambitious objective of representing minorities. Which is commendable in itself, but does nothing to challenge the dynamics that have moulded the entirety of American society since the early 1980s.

Location: 838

During her 2020 primary campaign, Kamala Harris talked about abolishing ICE (Immigration and Customs Enforcement), while also advocating public funding of sex-change operations for prisoners and illegal immigrants. Not only did these positions prove ineffective with primary voters, but they came back to haunt the candidate four years later. One of the most striking ads in Trump's 2024 campaign played on non-binary pronouns: 'Harris is for they/them; Trump is for you.' *

Location: 868

If the mobilization of prejudices has always been the lifeblood of political combat, social media has enabled it on an industrial scale. The principle is always the same. Three simple operations: identify the hot topics, the fracture points that divide public opinion; push the most extreme positions on these topics and get them in conflict with each other; get this conflict before as many eyeballs as possible, until the atmosphere grows overheated.

Location: 876

Silicon Valley engineers long ago stopped programming computers and became instead programmers of human behaviour. From the moment when we decided to make social media the global interface of our relationship with reality, we put ourselves in their hands. And in the hands of everyone, from influencers to spin doctors, whose interest is served by the overheating of the social climate.

Location: 879

During the 2022 presidential elections in France, the farright candidate Éric Zemmour made a telling Freudian slip. Intending to say: 'I only believe what I see,' he actually said: 'I only see what I believe.'

Location: 1,011

‘Elon, i’ve initiated a policy debate inspired by ideas from you and Milei. While migration control is crucial for Germany, the AfD stands against freedom, business—and it’s a far-right extremist party. Don’t rush to conclusions from afar. Let’s meet, and I’ll show you what the FDP stands for.’ Among the hundreds of thousands of messages posted daily on social media by politicians from all over the world, it is difficult to find one that is more pathetic, more simple-minded, more desperately naïve than this post from Christian Lindner, the former finance minister and leader of Germany’s liberal democrat party, sent on 20 December 2024 to Elon Musk. The response of the world’s richest man was not long in coming. ‘The traditional political parties in Germany have utterly failed the people. AfD is the only hope for Germany.’

Location: 1,024

The tech conquistadors have decided to get rid of the old political elites. If they get their way, the world of Lindner and all his kind—the liberals and the social democrats, the conservatives and the progressives: everything we have grown used to considering as the cornerstone of our democracies—will be swept away.

Location: 1,027

Until now, the economic elites—the financiers, entrepreneurs and CEOs—have relied on a political class of technocrats (or would-be technocrats) from the right and the left: moderate, boring, all more or less the same. These technocrats governed their countries on the basis of liberal democratic principles and in accordance with the rules of the market, sometimes tempered by social considerations. This was the Davos consensus.

Location: 1,035

The overlords of tech have far more in common with the Borgians. Like the Borgians, they are almost invariably outliers and outsiders who have had to break rules to achieve success. Like the Borgians, they are suspicious of experts and elites, of all those who represent the old guard and who might prevent them pursuing their dreams. Like the Borgians, they are men of action who believe they can mould reality to their own desires. Like the Borgians, they live in a world where profit trumps truth and where speed serves the strongest. Like the Borgians, they feel nothing but contempt for the politicians and the bureaucrats, seeing them as weak hypocrites whose time has come and gone. Thanks to the internet and social media, the weakness and hypocrisy of these former elites has been exposed to the eyes of the whole world.

Location: 1,111

For thirty years, from the mid 1990s to the present day, American Democrats have been bowing down to the tech entrepreneurs, enabling them to transform themselves from easy-going nerds with a hint of autism, promoting a future of universal brotherhood, into terrifying aliens, still with a hint of autism, engaged in a merciless war for planetary and intergalactic supremacy.

Location: 1,126

But what’s clear now is that, beyond their individual preferences, the convergence between the overlords of tech and the Borgians is structural. These two species of predators both draw their power from the digital revolution, and they cannot tolerate any limits to its will to power: the lawyers are their natural enemies, the prey that must be devoured to allow this new world to flourish.

Location: 1,214

Where his younger colleagues—Democrat lawyers or Davos optimates—saw only a technical development, Kissinger realized that the dawn of AI was also a political

development.

Location: 1,217

They may not have read the works of the French theologian François Fénelon, but they instinctively knew that humans cannot hope that a superior power will remain within the bounds of moderation.

Location: 1,220

The way he described it, AI was a Borgian technology, with its power residing in its capacity to produce shock and awe. Like the Borgians, AI feeds on chaos and turns it into surprise. Its capacity for action is still limited, of course, but the next generation of software, able to carry out tasks autonomously, is already on the horizon. Like the Borgians, AI does not care about rules or procedures. Nobody, not even its creators, knows how it comes to its decisions. All that matters is the result—‘Success!’ as Milei would say—with any and all means being justified by the desired ends. There is nothing democratic or transparent about the power of AI. Rather than artificial intelligence, AI is actually a form of authoritarian intelligence, centralizing data and transforming it into power. All of this in almost total obscurity, controlled by a handful of entrepreneurs and scientists, who are riding the tiger and hoping it doesn’t eat them alive.

Location: 1,230

In the twenty-first century, the decisive rift is becoming that between humans and machines. To what extent should our lives be subject to powerful digital systems—and on what conditions? Ultimately, individuals and societies are going to have to decide which aspects of life belong to human intelligence and which aspects we can entrust to AI, or to a collaboration between humans and AI. And every time they choose the human option, when AI could guarantee more efficient results, there will be a price to pay.

Location: 1,280

Today, we possess more information than ever before, and are less capable than ever before of predicting what will happen next. Our ancestors lived in far more data-poor societies than ours, but they were able to make plans for themselves and their descendants. We have ever less understanding of the world in which we will wake up tomorrow morning. This paradox is not conjunctural, but structural.

Location: 1,287

‘Fully imagined cultural futures were the luxury of another day, one in which “now” was of some greater duration,’ wrote the cyberpunk author William Gibson. For us, everything can change so suddenly that futures like those of our grandparents don’t have enough ‘now’ to last the pace. A reality like this one is a reality in which only Borgians feel comfortable, because they feed on chaos.

Location: 1,297

Like Kierkegaard's God, AI cannot be conceived in purely rational terms. The only way of entering into a relationship with it is through an act of faith. Its great promise is to predict, even if we don't understand. The tech overlords don't see why this is a problem. Since they are not interested in history or philosophy, they don't realize that what they're proposing is equivalent to going back in time to the age before the Enlightenment, to a world of incomprehensible magic, where we will pray to AI as our ancestors prayed to the old gods.

Location: 1,309

Years ago, following his first encounter with Hassabis, he was asking himself the most difficult yet important question: 'What will become of human consciousness if its own explanatory power is surpassed by AI, and societies are no able to interpret the world they inhabit in terms that are meaningful to them?'

Location: 1,329

If factory workers have been replaced by machines and delivery workers are increasingly being transformed into machines, the same phenomenon is now affecting white-collar workers and will soon reach the more learned professions: in the near future, doctors, accountants and lawyers will have to follow the AI's instructions and provide a justification whenever they make a decision that deviates from these guidelines. Only the most powerful will have any leeway, and even that may not last long.